



Paro Taktsang

Sacred Buddhist temples built on a precipitous mountainside in the Himalayas

Located in the kingdom of Bhutan in the eastern Himalayas, the Buddhist monastery of Paro Taktsang, widely known as the Tiger's Nest, clings to a cliffside 3,000 ft (900 m) above the Paro valley. The site is associated with Guru Rinpoche, also known as Padmasambhava, the revered master who is credited with introducing Tantric Buddhism to the area in the 8th century CE. Legend asserts that Rinpoche was carried to Taktsang from Tibet on the back of a tiger—hence the name Tiger's Nest. He meditated in a cave on the mountainside and, over the following centuries, many other Buddhist holy men imitated his example.

A home for the sacred

The monastery on the site was built in 1692 by Bhutan's ruler Gyalse Tenzin Rabgye. There are four temples and eight sacred caves, linked by vertiginous stepped paths and wooden bridges. The temples are in traditional Buddhist style, with plain white exterior walls and golden roofs. Some of the caves house religious statues and sacred scriptures. The monastery is still occupied by Buddhist monks today but it has also become a tourist destination. Paro Taktsang is the site of an annual Tsechu festival at which masked dancers celebrate Guru Rinpoche.



△ PRECARIOUS PERCH

The precarious location of Paro Taktsang makes the temples inaccessible for emergency assistance, and it burned down completely in a fire in 1998. It was restored to the form seen here in 2005.



△ GOLDEN SPIRES

The Temple of the Emerald Buddha and its surrounding buildings are a spectacular sight with the brightly colored tiles of their multilayered roofs and their glistening golden towers.

WAT PHRA KAEW

The walls of the Grand Palace enclose a total area of 2.35 million square ft (218,400 square m), within which the Temple of the Emerald Buddha (Wat Phra Kaew) stands in its own walled complex. The statue of the Emerald Buddha—carved from a single block of jade rather than emerald and dressed in gold clothing—is placed within the ordination hall, which is the main building in the complex.

